COMMENT

On the Mass Line

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While Mitch Meisner's analysis of Dazhai raises several significant issues concerning the mass line in Chinese politics (Meisner, 1978), the claim that it demonstrates "the mass line in practice" needs to be examined closely. Fortunately, we have come a long way from the tendency to view the mass line as a subtle form of manipulation by which the Chinese Communist Party more or less cynically uses the Chinese people to further its own interests (usually implicitly assumed to be counter to the people's interests). Especially after studies such as that of Selden (1971), the crucial role of mass activity in Chinese politics and revolution has become clearer. But given the importance of the concept of mass line, we must be careful how we locate it in any analysis of the Chinese Revolution. In particular, we must beware of any tendency to see anything connected with mass or lower-level political activity as indicating the operation of the mass line. Using only Mao Zedong's writings for the sake of brevity, I shall first suggest that Party leadership is central in Mao's conception of the mass line, and that, by failing to take sufficient account of this, Meisner systematically misinterprets the mass line. Second, I shall argue that what Meisner presents is an aberrant version of the mass line derived from the Cultural Revolution, and look briefly at the implications of the Cultural Revolution and its aftermath for the Party's mass line.

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PARTY LEADERSHIP

Although Mao frequently expresses faith in the masses' creativity and enthusiasm for revolutionary change, he also undoubtedly shares the Leninist skepticism of the possibility or efficacy of spontaneous mass activity. His writings and his political activity both have as central propositions the need for Party leadership in the Chinese Revolution. For analytical purposes, we can distinguish two bases for Mao's assertion of this need. The primary basis is that the Party must provide the revolutionary direction through the union of the "universal truths" of Marxism-Leninism with the "concrete practice" of the Chinese Revolution. Thus, the Party must consist of those revolutionaries who are distinguished not only by their commitment and consciousness, but, most importantly, who best understand the dynamics of the society in which they operate. In Mao's terms, they are able to apply the Marxist-Leninist dialectical method in the analysis of Chinese society, and then to use this analysis for defining revolutionary goals and formulating the appropriate strategy for their attainment (Mao, 1967a: 292-295, 1967b: 22-23, 37-38). Further, this theoretical understanding enables the Party to have a wider perspective, relating immediate tasks to longer-term objectives, and considering the total situation without being led astray by more particular factors. In less abstract terms, the Party must provide the policy guidance at all levels, from the general line defining the character of a whole revolutionary stage down to specific policies formulated by the Party at basic levels to deal with concrete situations.

This leads to the second basis of Party leadership, the organizational. The Party is the "highest form" of proletarian organization, first, because it collects together those revolutionaries who are most active, conscious, and skilled in Marxism-Leninism. Second, it must be an explicitly superior organizational form in order that its directional role can be realized. The Party's political guidance can be effected only through Party organizations and members exercising leadership over all areas of activity of state and society. And the Party organization integrates the policies applying at all levels, relating the general to the particular. Third, the Party must be a specific type of organization, adopting procedures which allow for the union of theory and practice and the definition of the "correct" direction at all levels.

The significance of Mao's mass line formulation is that it gives a particular definition of both the directional and organizational bases of Party leadership. If we begin with the recognized *locus classicus* of this

formulation, the essay "Some Questions Concerning Methods of Leadership" (Mao, 1967b: 117-122), in which Mao introduces the notion of "from the masses, to the masses," the first and most crucial point to note is that he is concerned with methods of leadership—specifically of Party leadership. The mass line is a line (that is, a systematic set of programs and policies with enduring validity) of the Party, and prescribes the proper relationship between the masses and Party leadership. Indicating the primary basis of Party leadership, the union of theory and practice, Mao also defines the mass line as an epistemology. The analysis of Chinese society on which the Party's direction is based must be derived from the Party members gathering the "scattered and unsystematic ideas" of the masses. This is linked to the materialist epistemology stressed in such formulas as "investigation and study" and "seeking truth from facts." In this sense, the Party must learn from the masses. Mao's emphasis on uniting theory and practice is especially opposed to "dogmatism," which is the attempted imposition of direction based on Marxist-Leninist formulas, phrases, or stereotypes, without detailed knowledge of the practical situation (Mao, 1967b: 22; 40-43). The failure to draw ideas from mass experience and to consider mass needs and consciousness is a principal form of dogmatism. But Mao is equally opposed to "empiricism," which "mistakes fragmentary experience for universal truth" (Mao, 1967b: 264), and is a fault committed by "the 'practical man' who gropes in the dark and lacks perspective and foresight" (Mao, 1967b: 13). Those rich in practical experience cannot remain content with this, but must realize that "they lack theory and their knowledge, too, is relatively incomplete" (Mao, 1967b: 41). Thus, Mao rejects the validity of detailed practical experience uninformed by the understanding derived from revolutionary theory.[1]

Mao's mass line formulation also concerns the necessity of mass participation in the translation of policy into action. Of crucial importance here is the relationship between Party cadres and the people among whom they operate, and this is reflected in Mao's continual stress on work style or methods of work. The cadres must be close to the masses, sensitive to mass wishes, demands, opinions, and consciousness. Mao criticizes the twin faults of "tailism" and "commandism": the former involves following mass demands irrespective of Party policy, or lagging behind the level of mass consciousness, while the latter is the attempt to enforce policy irrespective of mass consciousness (Mao, 1967b: 266). Mao demands a relationship between cadres and masses such that neither Party policy nor mass consciousness or wishes are neglected, what

he refers to as "the identity of our responsibility to the people and our responsibility to the leading organs of the Party" (Mao, 1967b: 265). The stress on mass consciousness in no way detracts from Party leadership, for the Party cadres must raise consciousness and, in the process, define it and channel it into action. This involves uniting the "relatively active," raising the level of the intermediate elements, and winning over the "relatively backward" (Mao, 1967b: 118). It also means that the cadres should persuade the masses to recognize the objective need for changes of which they are not yet subjectively conscious (Mao, 1967b: 186). Mao makes it clear that the relationship between Party and masses must be one between leaders and led.[2] Similarly, within the Party itself, the phenomenon of bureaucratism must be resisted because it may lead to dogmatism and commandism, which not only separate the higher from the lower levels of the Party but also thereby prevent mass inputs into higher levels of policy-making. Thus, the Party's internal procedures are also relevant to the successful operation of the mass line.

To return to Meisner's view of mass line, he argues:

> The mass line is founded in a materialist view that people have objective interests, that these can be grasped subjectively through practical experience, and that in the context of "revolutionizing practice" those interests are best perceived from the vantage point of "among the masses." This suggests that it is necessary for the subjective element of a mass viewpoint to find political expression and to be asserted from the solidity of a strong political base. Therefore, one might imagine the socialist transition period accompanied by the formation on a widening scale of more and more enlightened, self-directing communities of producers who were direct contributors to the material growth of the whole society. Politically, these "associations of producers" would have to be capable of standing up for their interests vis-a-vis bureaucratic or political hierarchies, while at the same time gaining the capacity to recognize as their own interests ones that tend to enhance the overall development of the society [1978: 28-29].

While accepting that people have objective interests, Mao's view of the mass line requires that it is the Party which, through its cadres, gauges mass wishes and consciousness and provides the interpretation of objective interests which is translated into policy. Thus, the political expression of "the subjective element of a mass viewpoint" has to be mediated through the Party and be subjected to Party leadership.[3] Meisner's imagination of "self-directing communities" may be projected at the

end of the socialist transition period, and Mao does envisage the withering away of the Party, but until then Party leadership is crucial. In particular, the Party must deal with the contradictions between particular interests and the "overall development of society." There are numerous obvious examples of the changing resolution of these contradictions—that is, changes in Party policy. To take one, that of land policy, presumably the redistribution of land was as much in the interests of the mass of poor peasants in 1942 as in 1947. Yet in the earlier period, the more moderate policy of reduction of rent and interest was adopted because of the Party's linking of the land policy to the overall situation created by the Anti-Japanese War. Only later, when the Party's definition of the overall situation had changed according to the new conditions, was the policy of land redistribution resumed. Such a policy shift could not be determined on the basis of knowledge of the situation in villages alone. It had to be on the basis of the Party's consideration of the whole situation facing the Chinese Revolution, its analysis of the relevant class forces in China's domestic and international environment, the categorization of the stage which the Revolution had reached and the main tasks this implied, and so on. These factors demanded a revolutionary organization which could transcend the limited horizon of practical experience of the needs of peasants in villages, and could link such particular factors to wider perspectives gained through a more encompassing organization and through recourse to the guiding political theory.

Finally, the notion of particular groups being capable of "standing up for their interests" against political hierarchies is, as a blanket statement, completely antithetical to the mass line. Indeed, it is significant here that Meisner puts together "authoritative levels in the Party and state" as if the distinction has no relevance to the mass line. Mao's view of the mass line explicitly sanctions the clear political dominance of the Party organization, which must be vertically integrated in order to cover the various levels of policy-making. The thrust of Mao's analysis does not deny a political hierarchy as such, but is concerned with the relationships between different levels of the necessarily dominant political organization and between that organization and the masses. The mobilization and strengthening of community power may be a desirable consequence of the mass line method of leadership, but to the extent that it asserts the autonomy of one local area from the general process of political direction through the Party organization, it is an infringement of the mass line.

The examples of political struggles in Dazhai which Meisner describes do not demonstrate "the mass line in practice." In Mao's interpretation, the mass line indicates a specific location of mass opinion and activity in the total process of Party direction and organized leadership over all levels of the revolutionary movement. Mass political activity is not in itself synonomous with the mass line; that is only true to the extent that it has the proper relationship with Party leadership. Meisner rightly points to the "recurring tendency towards rigidity" within the Party, and much of his analysis deals with the attempt of the Dazhai brigade to resist the increasing bureaucratization of the Party organization and the consequent separation of the higher levels from the lower and the masses. This serves to show the fragility of the mass line, since it demands types of behavior and relationship which can be undermined easily. But it also shows that the Dazhai brigade could maintain only some of the precepts of the mass line, especially the close relationship between the brigade cadres and the peasants. The mass line method has far wider implications than these, however, and the disobedience of leadership through the Party organizational structure and the flouting of higher-level policy demonstrate, on the contrary, the divergence from the basic principles of the mass line—uniting the general with the particular and the leadership with the masses, and the process of "from the masses to the masses" in the formulation of policy at all levels. These responses by the Dazhai brigade and its leaders may have been the best ones in a situation where the mass line was not operating, and may have led to other benefits such as community solidarity and material progress. But this does not justify the identification of any response to bureaucratic tendencies in the Party as the maintenance of the mass line. To analyze the mass line we must look far beyond the experience of a single area, since it encompasses the relationships between leaders and led, theory and practice, policy and mass activity, at all levels of the entire revolutionary movement.

MASS LINE AND CULTURAL REVOLUTION

Meisner's interpretation of the mass line relies very heavily on notions of mass political activity promoted in the Cultural Revolution. This is most obvious in some of the examples of Dazhai's resistance to the higher-level authorities, which fit into the framework of two-line

struggle advanced in the Cultural Revolution—for example, the opposition to the *xian* Party Secretary and especially to the Liuist-oriented work team in the Socialist Education Movement. But Meisner also deals with other central Cultural Revolutionary concepts. One of these is the need for "new inputs external to constituted leadership" in order to "maintain, renew or extend the practice of the mass line" (p. 29). A second is what Meisner terms "ideological authority," justifying action by reference to Mao's Thought, even in opposition to Party authorities. And a third is "democratic authority," which Meisner defines parenthetically as "following the desires of the masses." Meisner himself links these to the Cultural Revolution and the mass mobilization which was outside of the normal organizational channels, "although oriented to central authority via Mao and the Cultural Revolution Group." He also claims that this is not a one-sided emphasis on "democracy" or "spontaneity," since "understanding of the broad principles of the regime, or of the revolution, or of 'building a new socialist countryside' can be directly accessible to mass representatives, to basic-level cadres, and in the course of development, to the masses as a whole—through study, through discussion and understanding of the theoretical implications of their own activity" (pp. 56-57). In order to analyze the significance of these views for the mass line, it is worthwhile reviewing briefly some of the relevant aspects of the Cultural Revolution concerning mass activity and Party leadership.

The defined target of the Cultural Revolution was "Party persons in authority taking the capitalist road." The contradiction between such persons and the proletariat was seen as the "principal contradiction" and as "antagonistic." Throughout its course, the Cultural Revolution was explained as a continuation of class struggle, with the center of this struggle being the Party itself. This type of analysis can be traced back to the renewed stress on class struggle in socialist society at the Tenth Plenum of the Eighth Central Committee in 1962. It was related to the perception of the danger of "revisionism" and revolutionary reversal or the "restoration of capitalism." Mao in particular warned against the "new bourgeois elements" and the existence of a "capitalist faction" within the Party, and saw the success of revisionism as the "coming to power of the bourgeoisie" (Mao, 1969: 584, 598, 604). This is not the place to attempt a detailed exposition of this type of analysis.[4] Briefly, I would suggest that, from Mao's writings of the period and from other major documents in which Mao was almost certainly involved (those relating to the Socialist Education Movement and the

polemical dispute with the CPSU), there emerges a view of socialist revolution as a process defined by the direction of change and determined by class struggle. Since the aspects of the society which existed before the revolutionary seizure of power could be negated only gradually, there remains a persistent material basis for the regeneration of classes. The task of socialist revolution is progressively to negate this material basis, but there exists always the danger of movement in the opposite direction ("restoration of capitalism"). In this situation, the directional role of the Party becomes even more important. If the Party is leading in the wrong direction ("taking the capitalist road"), then this will amount to the defeat of the socialist revolution. Although these propositions were by no means clearly stated either before or during the Cultural Revolution,[5] they seem to me to be more in accord with Mao's views than other equally imprecise formulations such as that concerning class struggle as an ideological category ("bourgeois superstructure on a socialist economic base"). But irrespective of the type of underlying analysis, the definition of elements in the Party as the major enemy of the progress of socialist revolution had profound implications for the concept of Party leadership. It introduced a fundamental paradox. Not only is Party leadership necessary for socialist revolution, but it is also potentially the chief danger to socialist revolution. To return to the basic rationale for the role of the vanguard Party—that it must provide the revolutionary direction—it raises the question: what if the "vanguard" is leading in the wrong direction?

In the Cultural Revolution itself this problem was "solved" by the convenient notion of two-line struggle. This suggests that the "true" Party was that which could be identified with Mao and his "proletarian headquarters," while the conglomeration of "incorrect" lines from Chen Duxiu to Liu Shaoqi were necessarily "anti-Party." While this was absurdly ahistorical, it did restate the theoretical basis by which the revolutionary direction was to be provided. Mao Zedong thought had brought Marxism-Leninism to a new higher stage, and only this could be used as the criterion for judging the legitimacy of any political authority. This was used to justify the mass attack on Party organizations at all levels. Such organizations could not defend themselves by claiming that attacks on themselves were attacks on the Party, since the Party in itself was no longer legitimate, but only to the extent that it conformed to the leadership of Mao and his Thought.[6] The two roles of the Party, the directional and the organizational, which had been combined in a particular way in Mao's former formulation of the mass line, were now severed.

In this situation, the factors identified by Meisner—the need for new inputs into the political process, and the elevation of "ideological authority" and "democratic authority"—were clearly salient in the mass mobilization. Of particular relevance was the notion of "extensive democracy," which Xie Fuzhi advertised as "a signal development of Marxism-Leninism by Chairman Mao, one of equal importance and greatness with Marx's founding of scientific socialism and Lenin's founding of the seizure of political power by the proletariat of a single country" (Hsieh Fu-chih, 1967: 85). The significance of extensive democracy was that it was the means of overcoming the danger of capitalist restoration identified by Mao's analysis of continuing class struggle in socialist society (Li Guanchang, 1967; Yin Weichen, 1968). It provided the way of dealing with the situation in which the Party itself might pose the greatest threat to socialist revolution. Thus, it was new not only in the extent of mass activity, but also in the location of mass activity in the process of socialist revolution.

The crucial elements in this conception were mass activity and Mao's Thought. But more important was the linkage of these two elements in direct relationship, without any mediation by the Party organization. The masses, independently of leadership by Party organizations, were given the prime responsibility for the furtherance of socialist revolution:

> This extensive democracy is, under the command of Mao Zedong Thought, mobilising the hundreds of millions of the masses, to launch a general attack on the enemies of socialism, and at the same time to criticise and supervise leading organs and cadres at all levels. Creating this kind of social atmosphere of extensive democracy has important and far-reaching significance for consolidating the dictatorship of the proletariat and preventing capitalist restoration. Proletarian extensive democracy is a new development of Chairman Mao's mass line, a new form of integrating Mao Zedong Thought with the hundreds of millions of the masses. Extensive democracy is the best method for the masses to educate and liberate themselves [Renmin ribao and Hongqi, 1967:11].

This certainly was a "new development" of Mao's mass line, since it involved the conception of the direct relationship between Mao's Thought and the masses rather than a form of Party leadership. Party organizations do not have the role of guiding the mass movement, but must be criticized and supervised by the masses armed with Mao's

Thought. One typical article applauded that "the masses have themselves directly grasped Chairman Mao's correct line," and argued that this would be a great spur to leading comrades to carry out their work better (Hongqi, 1966: 1). This reinforced the underlying assumption that the masses would be more competent and more reliable in "grasping Mao's Thought" than those who were supposedly leaders.

This view of the mass line is close to Meisner's—although it goes even further in denying Party leadership, in that Meisner's example of Dazhai at least rests on the leading role of the Party branch, even if it does deny the authority of the Party organizational structure. It is clear how far this has deviated from the justification of Party leadership in terms of the need for guidance by a body which has a superior grasp of the revolutionary direction and which, through organized penetration of every level of society, can realize that direction in a coherent revolutionary movement. The discussion of organizational forms to be adopted early in the Cultural Revolution, however, indicated considerable ambiguity on the relationship between mass activity and Party leadership. The Central Committee's May 16 Circular of 1966 suggested that carrying out the Cultural Revolution "with the approval of the leading bodies concerned" would place restrictions on the "proletarian Left," since "most Party committees concerned have a very poor understanding of the task of leadership in this great struggle and their leadership is far from conscientious and effective" (CCP Central Committee, 1967: 10). This, combined with the repudiation of Party work teams sent down to control (or, it was argued, suppress) the early Cultural Revolution in universities, severely dented the legitimacy of Party organizational leadership. Nevertheless, the Sixteen Points Decision of August combined the need for the "masses to liberate themselves" with the need for Party leadership. It also tended to limit the focus of attack by asserting that capitalist-roaders were few, and most cadres were "good" or "comparatively good." But whatever affirmations of Party leadership remained were effectively negated by the growing Red Guard Movement, its broadening to include the workers, and the attacks on the Party organizations at all levels.

Of major significance in this early period was the use of the Paris Commune model. A *Hongqi* article on the eve of the Cultural Revolution drew out the implications of the Commune for mass participation. But it also saw the most significant negative experience of the Commune as the absence of "the leadership of a Marxist political party and the

guidance of Marxist theory" (Zheng Zhi-si, 1966: 10). But another article in the same journal in August repudiated this point. It strongly endorsed the Commune's general election system on the grounds that it "fully expressed the wishes and demands of the working class and other laboring people" (Liu Hui-ming, 1966: 37). Thus, it suggested that the revolution was best carried out through direct mass determination of the political process. This was an implicit denial of the need for the leading role of the vanguard party. That Mao in particular was unwilling to countenance this position is indicated by his reported comment on the Shanghai Commune established in February 1967:

> If everything became Commune, what about the Party? Where would we put the Party? In the Commune Committee there are Party members and non-Party members; where would we put the Party Committee? There certainly must be a Party! There must be a nucleus, no matter what it is called. Whether it is called the Communist Party, the social democratic party, the social democratic workers' party, the Guomindang, or the Yiguandao, it must have a party. The Commune certainly must have a party, but can the Commune substitute for the party? [Mao, 1969: 670-671]

Mao's answer to the last question is clearly in the negative. He may have been willing to stimulate mass attacks on Party organizations which he considered had gone astray, but not to abandon the notion of leadership by a vanguard party.

Throughout the Cultural Revolution, therefore, there was both a recognition of the need for Party leadership and the effective destruction of the role of Party organizations. In that case, "Party leadership" tended to mean the ideological leadership of Mao and his "proletarian headquarters." For example, the concept of democratic centralism was used in such a way that it was separated from any organizational referent, and became the union of extensive democracy with the centralized guidance of Mao Zedong Thought. But some of the consequences of this separation of ideological direction from organizational leadership support Mao's original arguments concerning the need for a vanguard both ideologically and organizationally. The movement was plagued by tendencies which were condemned as "factionalism" and "anarchism," but which were the direct result of a situation in which, with the role of Party organizations destroyed, there could be no authoritative translation of ideological precepts into policy at lower levels.

The central leadership railed against such problems as "mountain stronghold mentality," "small group mentality," "ultrademocracy," "theory of many centers, that is, no center," and so on. It also attempted to promote the "proletarian Party character," which stressed the subordination of individual or small group interests to the interests of the whole revolutionary movement. But these attempts at ideological guidance could not in themselves be effective, without the means of achieving organizational coherence. Ideological precepts were subject to varying interpretations and led to factional disagreements. And it did little good to stress revolutionary discipline, since this was inevitably undermined by the prime revolutionary quality of the "spirit of rebellion." Any authority interpreted as following the incorrect line had to be rejected; if not, this would constitute a return to Liu's heinous views of "docile tools" and "slavishness."

Despite the adoption of various organizational forms, including revolutionary committees, workers' propaganda teams, and PLA teams, "factionalism" and "anarchism" were intractable phenomena. They persisted after the Ninth Congress, and continued to pose problems for the process of Party rebuilding. At the Ninth Congress, such concepts as "extensive democracy" were reaffirmed, but they became increasingly hollow, and by the end of 1970, the crucial role of leadership through Party organizations was firmly reestablished (Young, 1978: 42-56). This was still put within the context of continuing class struggle within socialist society. Now, however, the Party was definitely the "highest form of proletarian organization." Without it, the proletariat would be unable to assimilate Marxism, adopt united programs, and change from a "class in itself" to a "class for itself" (Yunnan renmin chubanshe, 1970: 21). The leading role of Party organizations was directly equated with the adherence to the leadership of Mao and his Thought (Yunnan renmin chubanshe, 1970: 47). And, just as Party organizations had to be superior to all other organizations, so the "advanced elements" of the proletariat had to be distinguished from the "general masses" (Xinhua Correspondent, 1970). While there was criticism of "the masses are backward," it was balanced by the criticism of "doing what the masses want" and "tailism" (Yunnan renmin chubanshe, 1970: 132-136). Liu Shaoqi, as well as being accused of disparaging the mass movement, was also charged with advocating mass spontaneity and negating Party leadership. Party leadership and the mass line "entirely coincide" and form "a relationship of dialectical unity" (Yunnan renmin chubanshe, 1970: 94). Thus, there was a retreat from the notions of mass activity

which had been propagated during the Cultural Revolution, and a return to the conception of the mass line as a method of Party leadership.

In many ways the mass movement of the Cultural Revolution corresponds to the interpretation of the mass line Meisner develops with respect to Dazhai. It tended to carry to extremes the "new inputs" of mass activity and the "ideological authority" and "democratic authority" which he identifies. But in each case what is happening is far from the conception of the mass line which Mao had developed before the Cultural Revolution. The center of that conception is Party direction and organized leadership of the whole revolutionary movement. This is denied partially in Dazhai's case by the assertion of autonomy from the Party organization by the brigade Party branch, and is denied almost completely in the Cultural Revolution by the destruction of the Party organization. We should avoid equating the view of mass activity which emerged in the Cultural Revolution with the mass line; it is best seen as a situation of unprecedented mass activity *without* the mass line. And since the Cultural Revolution, the assertion of the centrality of the Party organization, has returned, and with it the mass line as a method of Party leadership.[7] As always, the mass line is a very fragile ideal. It depends on intangible factors such as the proper attitudes and work methods of Party members and organizations, and the maintenance of proper political relationships within the Party and between the Party and the masses. Such fragility is inevitable in the delicate attempt to combine mass activity with Party leadership. Any analysis of the mass line must take into account both of these aspects, however, if it is not to distort our understanding of both Mao's Thought and the Chinese Revolution. Meisner's analysis tends toward this distortion, first by misinterpreting the crucial role of Party leadership in the mass line, and second, by stressing an aberrant view of the mass line developed only briefly in the Cultural Revolution and since abandoned.

NOTES

1. While the context is not made clear, one of the statements of Chen Yonggui which Meisner quotes with approval seems to come close to what Mao means by "empiricism": "we have our practice behind our resistance—not our ideas" (p. 42). And the same is so of Meisner's own summary, that "if practice is *of* (and by) the masses, then truth and thereby unity, are *from* the masses" (p. 43).

2. This can also be related to Mao's notion of democratic-centralism, the paradox to which Meisner refers. While democratic-centralism as an organizational principle applies within the Party, the relationship between the aspects of "democracy" and "centralism" applies also to the Party's relations with the masses. By arguing that "without democracy there cannot be any correct centralism," Mao is not denying that there could be a situation of imposition of central control at the expense of lower-level initiative and participation. "Correct centralism," however, implies something more. On one level it refers to coordination and the flow of information on which decisions are based. But Mao's argument also relates to the Party's role in providing guidance for the revolutionary movement. The Party may be seen as a processing plant, but this is clearly in an active and not a passive sense. The Party must use the various inputs (mass opinions etc.) to produce "correct" outputs on the basis of its superior grasp of Marxist-Leninist theory—authoritative general and specific policies—by which it can lead the masses more effectively and "correctly" (Mao, 1962: 163-164).

3. A similar point can be made with respect to Meisner's proposition: "that any so-called correct line can only emerge and be recognised practically in a political process wherein local communities work as active political subjects on behalf of their perceived interests and concerns, are aware of the reasons behind their own experience, and have access to an autonomous standpoint for judging their reality" (p. 32). Such autonomy may have led to splendid results in furthering socialist goals in Dazhai, but can this be assumed to be a generally likely outcome? It is not difficult to imagine, for example, a community of peasants, working as "active political subjects," perceiving their interests as being the expansion of private plots. While recognizing the importance of practice in defining "correctness," Meisner's proposition plays down the extent to which this practice must be theory-directed, and the way in which this provides a necessary criterion for judging "correctness." Second, it tends to view consciousness statically, neglecting the need to raise consciousness and to relate it to the attainment of wider or longer-term revolutionary goals.

4. This argument is further developed in Young and Woodward (1978a: 33-38, 1978b).

5. They were more fully developed in the 1975 campaign to study the theory of the dictatorship of the proletariat, including the two important articles by Zhang (Chang, 1975) and Yao (1975).

6. This was most forcefully presented in an article by Lin Jie (1967), which attacked Li Shaoqi's supposed advocacy of "slavishness."

7. At the same time, the reassertion of Party organizational leadership leaves major questions concerning socialist revolution in China unsolved. Extensive democracy was justified as an enduring necessity in terms of the perceived problems concerning the degeneration of the Party and its role in the restoration of capitalism. The new stress on the inviolability of Party leadership does not confront the question of what to do if the vanguard is leading in the wrong direction. Although the need for Party leadership has not been challenged, there have been since the Cultural Revolution several major political struggles concerning the meaning and implications of the theory of continuous revolution—most recently, those involving the so-called "Gang of Four."

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